Headache diary · 8 weeks

Name _____ Start date _____

How to use it

1. Fill in one row every day. On a day without headache, write N under Headache? and leave the rest blank: pain-free days count too.
2. Note when a headache started and ended, and the worst pain from 0 (none) to 10 (worst imaginable). If it goes on past midnight, write "cont." under Started on the next day's row.
3. Write every painkiller or headache medicine you take, prescribed or not, with the dose and time, and whether it helped. Include painkillers taken for other pain, such as period pain.
4. After each 4 weeks, fill in the summary on page 6. Bring the diary to your appointment. For longer, print another copy.

UK guidance (NICE CG150) suggests keeping a headache diary for at least 8 weeks: how often, how long and how bad; other symptoms; all medicines; possible triggers; and any link to your period.

Key

Symptoms	N nausea or vomiting · L light bothers you · S sound bothers you A aura: warning signs such as zigzag lines, flashing lights or pins and needles, usually less than 1 hour
Kind of medicine	T triptan C combination painkiller, such as one with caffeine or codeine P simple painkiller: paracetamol/acetaminophen, aspirin, ibuprofen or another NSAID O other medicine for the attack: opioid, ergot or another (write its name)
Helped?	Y yes · S somewhat · N no
Period	tick days you have your period

Call your local emergency number if a headache comes with any of these:

- Extremely bad pain that came on suddenly
- Weakness or loss of movement on one side of your body or face
- Problems speaking or remembering things
- Losing your vision, or blurred or double vision
- Feeling drowsy or confused
- A seizure or fit
- A very high temperature and signs of meningitis, such as a stiff neck
- A rash that doesn't fade when you press a glass against it (this may be harder to see on brown or black skin)
- A head injury in the last 3 months

Don't drive yourself to hospital. Call your local emergency number.

Get urgent medical advice if you have a migraine attack and:

- It has lasted longer than 72 hours
- Aura symptoms last longer than 1 hour at a time
- You're pregnant or have just had a baby

If you have any other symptoms you're worried about, get urgent medical advice.

Why count medicine days?

Taking medicine for attacks on many days a month can make headaches more frequent. The international classification (ICHD-3) describes medication-overuse headache in people with headache on 15 or more days a month who, for more than 3 months, have taken: triptans, ergots, opioids or combination painkillers on 10 or more days a month; a mix of these kinds, or of these and simple painkillers, on 10 or more days in total; or simple painkillers alone (one or several) on 15 or more days.

These counts are for diagnosis; the everyday advice is lower: the NHS suggests not taking painkillers on more than 2 days a week. Talk to your doctor, and don't stop or change medicines on your own.

Weeks 1–2

From _____

Date	Headache? Y / N	Started time	Ended time	Worst pain 0–10	Symptoms N L S A	Medicine taken name, dose, time	Kind T C P O	Helped? Y / S / N	Possible triggers	Period tick	Notes

Weeks 3–4

From _____

Date	Headache? Y / N	Started time	Ended time	Worst pain 0–10	Symptoms N L S A	Medicine taken name, dose, time	Kind T C P O	Helped? Y / S / N	Possible triggers	Period tick	Notes

Weeks 5–6

From _____

Date	Headache? Y / N	Started time	Ended time	Worst pain 0–10	Symptoms N L S A	Medicine taken name, dose, time	Kind T C P O	Helped? Y / S / N	Possible triggers	Period tick	Notes

Weeks 7–8

From _____

Date	Headache? Y / N	Started time	Ended time	Worst pain 0–10	Symptoms N L S A	Medicine taken name, dose, time	Kind T C P O	Helped? Y / S / N	Possible triggers	Period tick	Notes

Summary for your doctor

Count days, not doses: a day with two doses counts once, and a day with T and P counts under both, and once under any medicine for the attack.

	Headache days	Days with N, L, S or A	Days with P	Days with T	Days with C	Days with O	Days with any medicine for the attack	Worst pain
Weeks 1–4								
Weeks 5–8								

Medicines I take to prevent headaches

Questions for my doctor